



ANA › Life Services Authority › Free and Accepted Mason

History of Freemasonry in America

American Freemasonry predates the nation itself — the first lodge on American soil received its charter in 1733, more than four decades before the Declaration of Independence. This page traces the full arc of Masonic history in America: the colonial lodges, the fraternity's entanglement with the Founding Fathers, the Anti-Masonic convulsions of the 1820s, the post-war expansion that turned a philosophical brotherhood into a mass institution, and the long membership decline that reshaped the fraternity after 1960. The record is richer, stranger, and more contested than either its admirers or critics tend to admit.

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Definition and Scope

Freemasonry in America is not a single organization. It is a federated system of independently chartered grand lodges — one per state, plus grand lodges in the District of Columbia and several U.S. territories — each governing the symbolic or "blue lodge" craft degrees within its jurisdiction. At its peak in 1959, American Freemasonry counted approximately 4.1 million members, according to the Masonic Service Association of North America ([MSANA](#)). By 2022, that number had contracted to roughly 1.1 million, a structural transformation that mirrors broader trends in voluntary association across American civic life.

The scope of "American Freemasonry" properly includes the blue lodge system, the [Grand Lodge system](#) that governs it, and the constellation of appendant bodies — the Scottish Rite, York Rite, Shriners, and others — that build on the craft degrees. All of those are connected to, but legally distinct from, the independent grand lodges. That jurisdictional layering is not an accident; it is a founding design principle rooted in the fraternity's British inheritance and its early American adaptation.

Core Mechanics or Structure

The structural foundation of American Freemasonry was laid at the provincial level under British authority before independence. The first warranted lodge in the American colonies — St. John's Lodge in Boston — received its charter from the Grand Lodge of England in 1733. By the time of the Revolution, more than 100 lodges were operating across the colonies under charters from English, Irish, or Scottish grand lodges.

The break from British authority produced a distinctly American innovation: the independent state grand lodge. The Grand Lodge of Virginia was established in 1778, with [notable Freemasons including George Washington](#) and Edmund Randolph among its early members (Virginia Grand Lodge records). Massachusetts followed in 1792, consolidating rival "Ancient" and "Modern" lodge systems that had operated in parallel since the 1750s. By 1800, grand lodges had been formed in 11 states, each sovereign within its own territory — a federal model that mirrored the constitutional structure the same men were simultaneously debating.

Within each state, individual lodges confer 3 degrees: Entered Apprentice, Fellowcraft, and Master Mason. These degrees form what is called the [blue lodge](#) — the foundational unit of the entire institution. Governance runs upward from lodge to grand lodge; there is no national grand lodge in the United States, a structural fact that distinguishes American Freemasonry from many European systems.

Causal Relationships or Drivers

Three distinct forces shaped American Freemasonry's growth and decline across three centuries.

Enlightenment sociability. The colonial lodges were not primarily secret societies in the conspiratorial sense — they were voluntary associations for men who wanted a structured venue for philosophical discussion, mutual aid, and social networking at a time when civil society had few other forms. The lodge filled a specific institutional gap. Taverns were too informal; churches were denominational. The lodge was neither.

Revolutionary-era prestige. The fraternity's association with the Founding generation — Washington, Franklin, Paul Revere, John Hancock — gave American Freemasonry a civic legitimacy that proved extraordinarily durable. That association is documented in the Proceedings of the Grand Lodge of Massachusetts and contemporaneous lodge records. It also created a mythology that periodically overreached the historical evidence, contributing directly to the backlash described below.

Post-Civil War fraternal culture. Between 1865 and 1920, fraternal organizations of all kinds exploded in membership across the United States. Freemasonry was the prestige anchor of that ecosystem. Lodges provided life insurance functions, social networks, and ritual meaning in an era before the welfare state. The [Masonic charities and foundations](#) that still operate today — hospitals, orphanages, scholarship funds — were largely built during this period of institutional expansion.



Classification Boundaries

American Freemasonry is frequently confused with things it is not. Four distinctions clarify the institutional map:

Freemasonry vs. appendant bodies. The [Scottish Rite and York Rite](#) require Master Mason membership as a prerequisite, but they are chartered separately and operate under their own governance. The Shriners International (formerly Ancient Arabic Order of Nobles of the Mystic Shrine) dropped its Masonic membership requirement in 2000, making it legally distinct in a new way.

Mainstream vs. irregular Freemasonry. Grand lodges that recognize each other as legitimate practice "regular" Freemasonry under protocols derived from the 1723 Constitutions of James Anderson and the 1929 Basic Principles of Grand Lodge Recognition (United Grand Lodge of England). Prince Hall grand lodges — historically Black American Masonic bodies chartered beginning with African Lodge No. 459 in 1784 — were denied recognition by most mainstream

grand lodges for nearly two centuries. By 2023, 42 of 51 mainstream U.S. grand lodges had extended formal recognition to their Prince Hall counterparts ([MSANA](#)).

Lodge vs. grand lodge authority. Individual lodges cannot create new degrees, change ritual, or admit candidates outside grand lodge rules. The sovereignty resides at the grand lodge level.

Tradeoffs and Tensions

The Anti-Masonic movement of the 1820s and 1830s is the sharpest case study in the fraternity's structural vulnerabilities. The 1826 disappearance of William Morgan — a New York man who threatened to publish Masonic rituals — and the subsequent failure to convict any Masons in connection with his presumed murder, triggered the first third-party political movement in American history, the Anti-Masonic Party. New York grand lodge membership fell by approximately 75 percent between 1826 and 1835 (records cited in Steven Bullock's *Revolutionary Brotherhood*, University of North Carolina Press, 1996). The episode exposed a permanent tension in American Freemasonry: the fraternity's opacity, its operational value as a fellowship, is also its greatest public liability when trust breaks down.



A second, ongoing tension runs between racial inclusion and institutional history. The mainstream grand lodge system's long exclusion of Prince Hall lodges was not a peripheral quirk — it was a defining structural feature for nearly 200 years. The gradual recognition process since the 1980s has changed the formal landscape, but 9 mainstream grand lodges had still not extended recognition as of publicly available MSANA records.

Common Misconceptions

Misconception: The Founding Fathers were predominantly Freemasons.

The historical record is more selective. Of the 56 signers of the Declaration of Independence, 9 have documented Masonic membership (Robert Davis, *Understanding Manhood in America*, 2005; Masonic records). Washington was indeed a Mason, initiated in Fredericksburg Lodge No. 4 in 1752. Benjamin Franklin was Grand Master of Pennsylvania. But most signers were not members, and attributing the founding documents to Masonic design overstates the organizational influence.

Misconception: American Freemasonry is a single national body.

There is no national grand lodge. The 51 grand lodges are each jurisdictionally sovereign. A Mason suspended or expelled by one grand lodge may be recognized in a different jurisdiction under different rules — a fact that surprises people who assume centralized governance.

Misconception: The Master Mason degree ceremony confers membership in a secret government.

The degrees confer membership in a fraternal lodge. The [legend of Hiram Abiff](#) at the core of the third degree is allegorical, not operational instruction. The [masonic ritual explained](#) in published Masonic education materials makes this clear.

Key Events Timeline

A structured chronology for reference:

1. **1717** — Grand Lodge of England founded in London; provides the institutional model for all subsequent grand lodges.
 2. **1733** — St. John's Lodge, Boston, chartered; first warranted lodge on American soil.
 3. **1752** — George Washington initiated in Fredericksburg Lodge No. 4, Virginia.
 4. **1778** — Grand Lodge of Virginia established; first independent American grand lodge.
 5. **1784** — African Lodge No. 459 chartered under the Grand Lodge of England; foundation of the Prince Hall tradition.
 6. **1826–1832** — William Morgan affair triggers Anti-Masonic Party; membership collapses in northeastern states.
 7. **1865–1920** — Post-Civil War fraternal expansion; Masonic membership grows to become the largest fraternal institution in the United States.
 8. **1959** — American Freemasonry reaches peak membership of approximately 4.1 million (MSANA).
 9. **1989** — Connecticut Grand Lodge becomes the first mainstream grand lodge to recognize a Prince Hall grand lodge.
 10. **2000** — Shriners International removes Masonic membership requirement.
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Reference Table: Major Periods in American Masonic History

Period	Years	Defining Feature	Peak/Nadir
Colonial Provincial Era	1733–1776	British-chartered lodges; tavern sociability	~100 lodges by 1776
Founding & Federal Era	1776–1820	Independent state grand lodges formed; civic prestige	11 grand lodges by 1800
Anti-Masonic Crisis	1826–1840	Morgan affair; political backlash; mass resignations	~75% membership loss in NY
Victorian Fraternal Expansion	1865–1920	Charitable institutions built; mass membership culture	Sustained growth
Mid-Century Peak	1940–1960	Post-WWII lodge boom; civic institution status	4.1M members (1959)
Structural Decline	1960–present	Membership attrition; Prince Hall recognition progress	~1.1M members (2022)

The full scope of [Freemasonry's foundational principles and degrees](#) connects this historical arc to the living institutional structure that operates in lodges across all 50 states today.



References

- [IRS Tax-Exempt Organization Resources](#)
- [IRS Fraternal Beneficiary Societies \(501\(c\)\(8\)\)](#)
- [DOL Fraternal Organization Guidance](#)

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